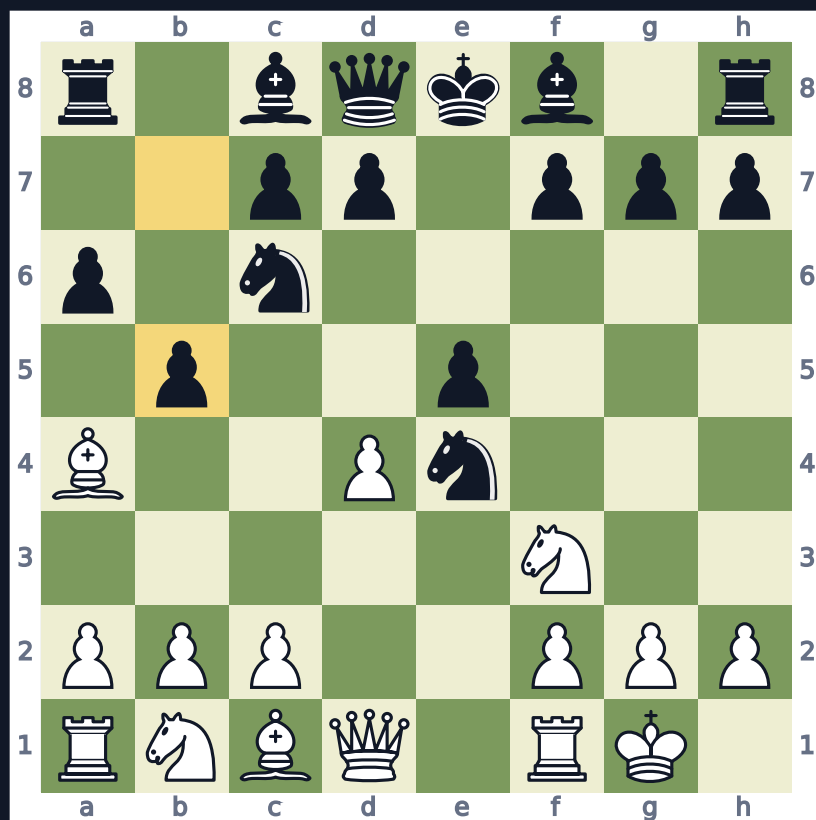


10

The Open Spanish

The e4 knight, Black's central activity, and White's attack on the d5 base.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will calculate the forcing sequence that justifies 5...Nxe4 and understand the positional targets after the tactics settle.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate candidates for the side to move, identify the opponent's strongest resource, and choose the resulting structure you can explain. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 055 | PAGE 4

Decode: Why 5...Nxe4 works

The Open Spanish pawn capture is sound because the center arrives behind it.

LESSON 056 | PAGE 8

Play: Why 5...Nxe4 works

The Open Spanish pawn capture is sound because the center arrives behind it.

LESSON 057 | PAGE 12

Decode: White attacks the d5 base

Attack the base of an active center; its advanced piece often depends on it.

LESSON 058 | PAGE 16

Play: White attacks the d5 base

Attack the base of an active center; its advanced piece often depends on it.

LESSON 059 | PAGE 20

Decode: Piece activity as compensation

Dynamic compensation expires; convert it into development, tactics, or a sound structure.

LESSON 060 | PAGE 24

Play: Piece activity as compensation

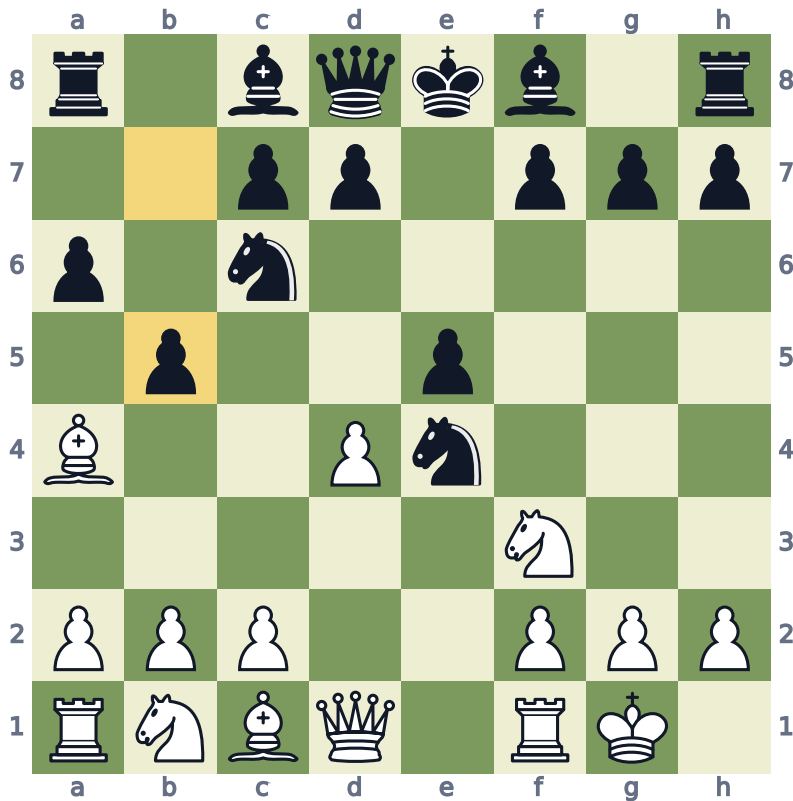
Dynamic compensation expires; convert it into development, tactics, or a sound structure.

VOLUME OBJECTIVE

You will calculate the forcing sequence that justifies 5...Nxe4 and understand the positional targets after the tactics settle.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Why 5...Nxe4 works



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black can take e4 because ...d5 supports the knight and opens active lines; the apparent pawn grab is a prepared central system.

DECISION RULE

After White's next forcing move, where can the e4 knight go and which pawn holds the center together?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Keep the knight coordinated, develop with tempo, and use the broad center before White attacks its base.

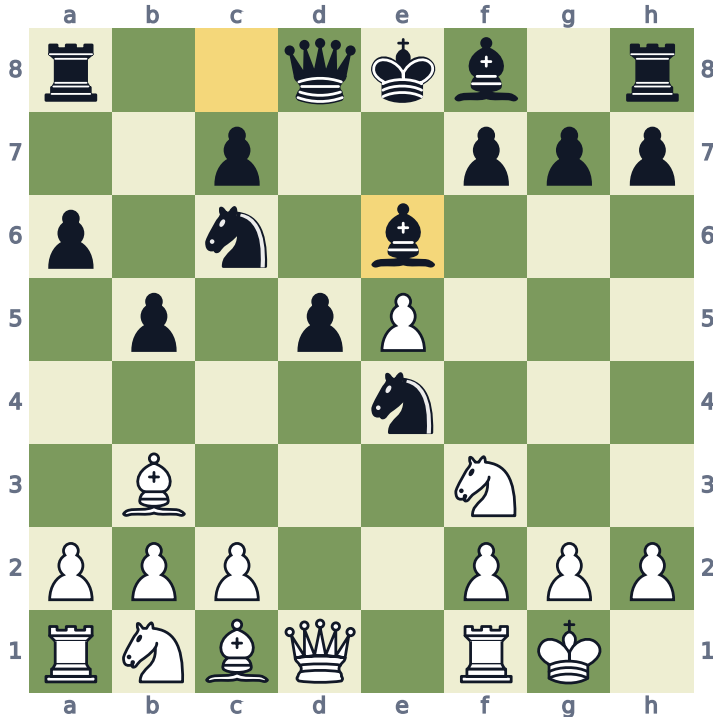
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White challenges the center immediately and uses pins against c6 and tactical pressure on d5.

MEMORY RULE | The Open Spanish pawn capture is sound because the center arrives behind it.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black can take e4 because ...d5 supports the knight and opens active lines; the apparent pawn grab is a prepared central system.

BLACK'S PLAN

Keep the knight coordinated, develop with tempo, and use the broad center before White attacks its base.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White challenges the center immediately and uses pins against c6 and tactical pressure on d5.

FAILURE MODE

Taking e4 in a move order where ...d5 cannot support the knight.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After White's next forcing move, where can the e4 knight go and which pawn holds the center together? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

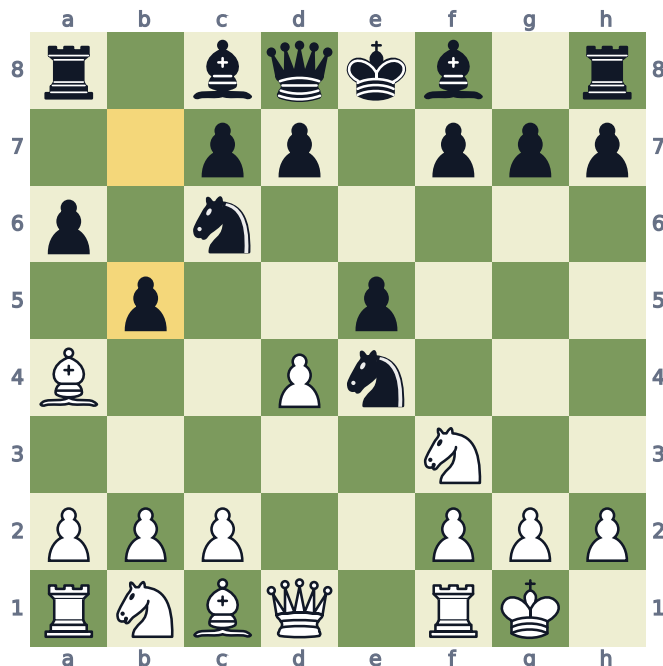
RULE | The Open Spanish pawn capture is sound because the center arrives behind it.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6



- Ba4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Nxe4: Black releases tension by capturing on e4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- d4: White challenges e5 and opens lines after the preparatory pieces are ready.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black can take e4 because ...d5 supports the knight and opens active lines; the apparent pawn grab is a prepared central system.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After White's next forcing move, where can the e4 knight go and which pawn holds the center together? White's resource is: White challenges the center immediately and uses pins against c6 and tactical pressure on d5. The line fails as a template when: Taking e4 in a move order where ...d5 cannot support the knight.

STORE THIS | The Open Spanish pawn capture is sound because the center arrives behind it.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

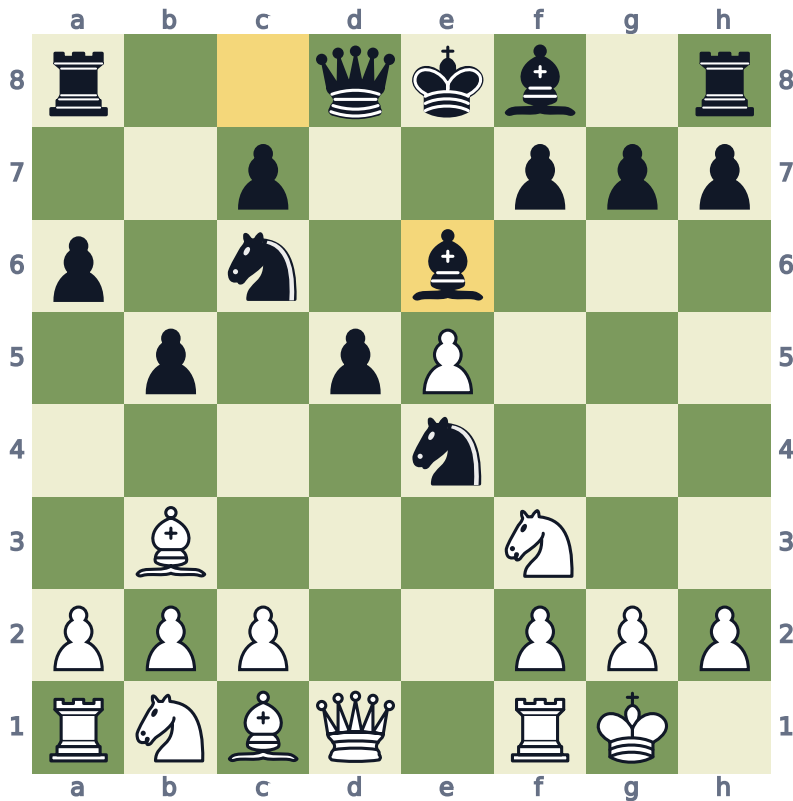
1. Black can take e4 because ...d5 supports the knight and opens active lines; the apparent pawn grab is a prepared central system. 2. Keep the knight coordinated, develop with tempo, and use the broad center before White attacks its base. 3. White challenges the center immediately and uses pins against c6 and tactical pressure on d5. 4. After White's next forcing move, where can the e4 knight go and which pawn holds the center together? 5. Taking e4 in a move order where ...d5 cannot support the knight.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Why 5...Nxe4 works



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black can take e4 because ...d5 supports the knight and opens active lines; the apparent pawn grab is a prepared central system.

DECISION RULE

After White's next forcing move, where can the e4 knight go and which pawn holds the center together?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Keep the knight coordinated, develop with tempo, and use the broad center before White attacks its base.

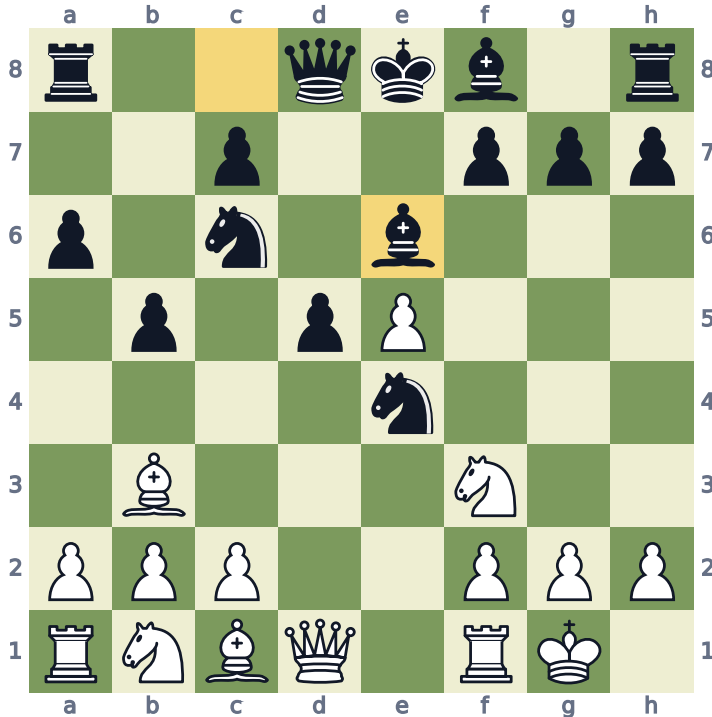
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK'S PLAN

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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White challenges the center immediately and uses pins against c6 and tactical pressure on d5.

FAILURE MODE

Taking e4 in a move order where ...d5 cannot support the knight.

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Ask: After White's next forcing move, where can the e4 knight go and which pawn holds the center together? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

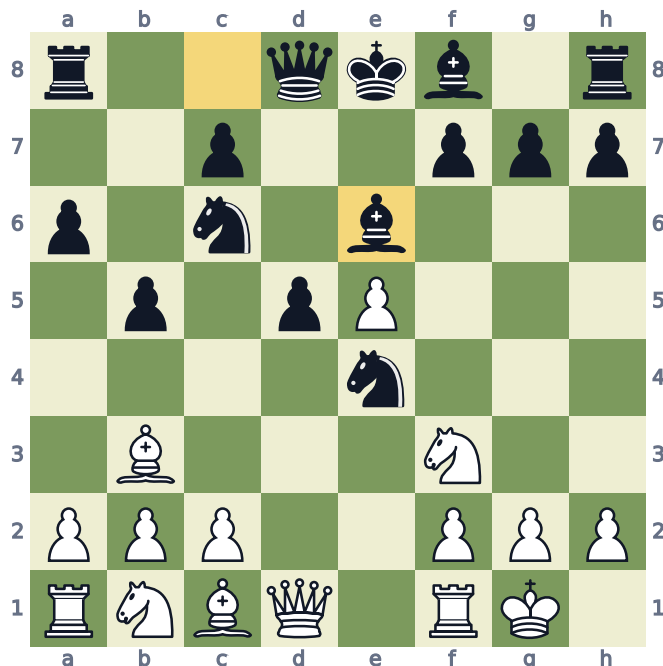
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6



- d4: White challenges e5 and opens lines after the preparatory pieces are ready.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.
- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d5: Black challenges the center or offers dynamic activity, depending on the system.
- dxe5: White releases tension by capturing on e5; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Be6: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black can take e4 because ...d5 supports the knight and opens active lines; the apparent pawn grab is a prepared central system.

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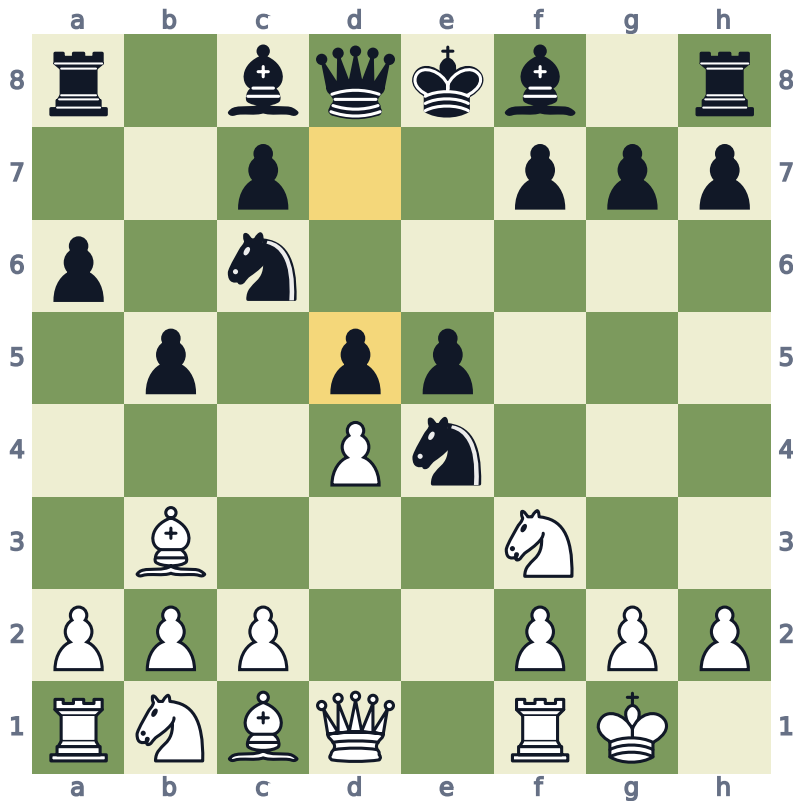
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: White attacks the d5 base



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White does not chase the knight blindly; c3 and Nbd2 add pressure to the central base and improve development.

DECISION RULE

Which defender of d5 is pinned, overloaded, or vulnerable to exchange?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black defends d5 dynamically, castles, and uses piece activity to prevent White from collecting central pawns.

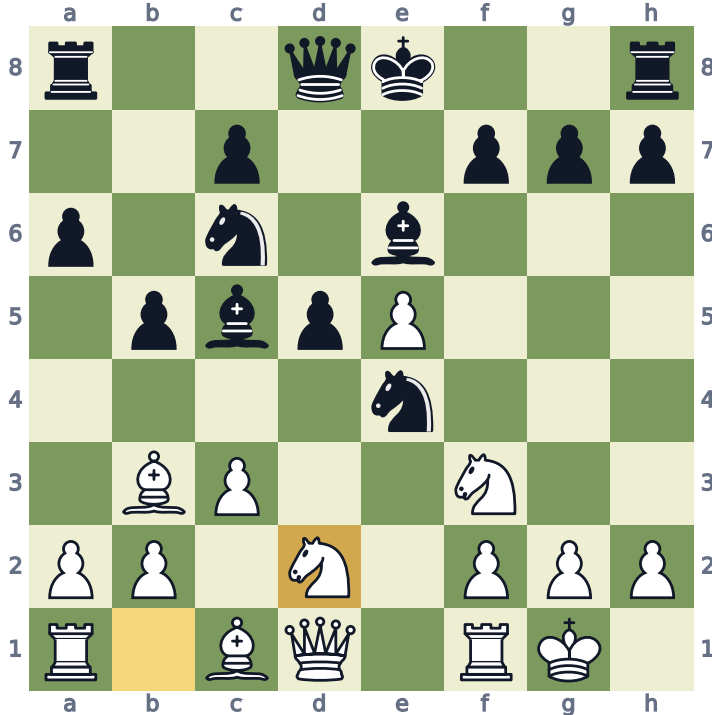
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White attacks d5 and e4 while keeping tactical pressure on f7 and the pinned c6 knight.

MEMORY RULE | Attack the base of an active center; its advanced piece often depends on it.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

White does not chase the knight blindly; c3 and Nbd2 add pressure to the central base and improve development.

BLACK'S PLAN

Black defends d5 dynamically, castles, and uses piece activity to prevent White from collecting central pawns.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S PLAN

White attacks d5 and e4 while keeping tactical pressure on f7 and the pinned c6 knight.

FAILURE MODE

Black defending the pawn passively or White taking before completing the tactical sequence.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which defender of d5 is pinned, overloaded, or vulnerable to exchange? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

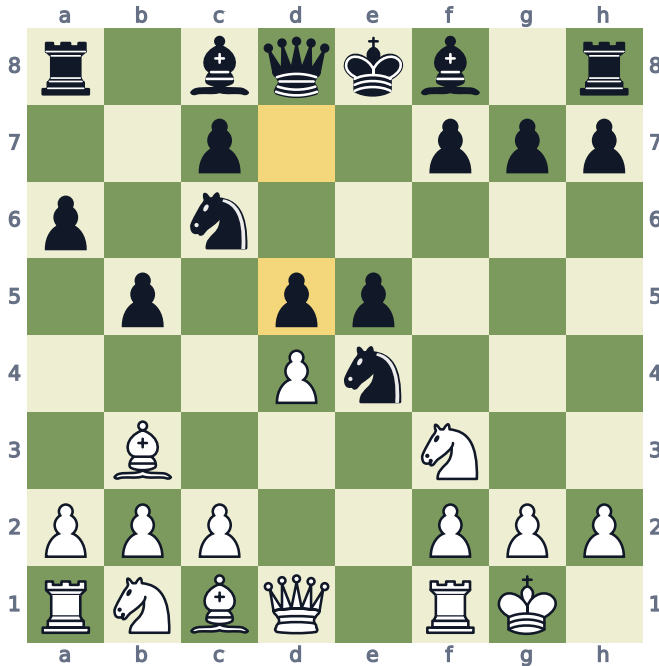
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Nxe4: Black releases tension by capturing on e4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- d4: White challenges e5 and opens lines after the preparatory pieces are ready.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.
- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
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WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White does not chase the knight blindly; c3 and Nbd2 add pressure to the central base and improve development.

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Which defender of d5 is pinned, overloaded, or vulnerable to exchange? White's resource is: White attacks d5 and e4 while keeping tactical pressure on f7 and the pinned c6 knight. The line fails as a template when: Black defending the pawn passively or White taking before completing the tactical sequence.

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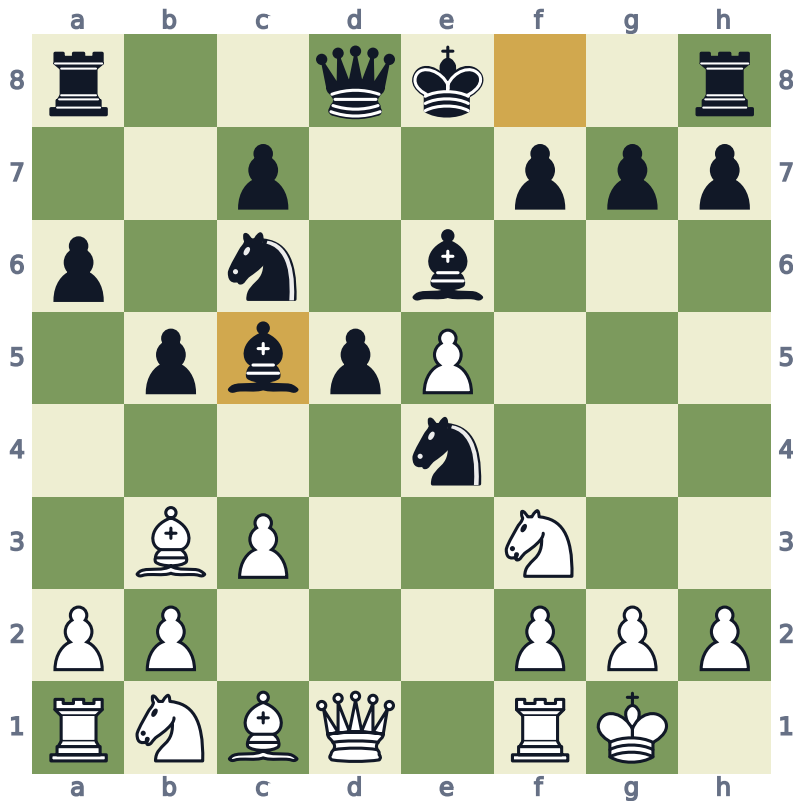
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: White attacks the d5 base



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White does not chase the knight blindly; c3 and Nbd2 add pressure to the central base and improve development.

DECISION RULE

Which defender of d5 is pinned, overloaded, or vulnerable to exchange?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

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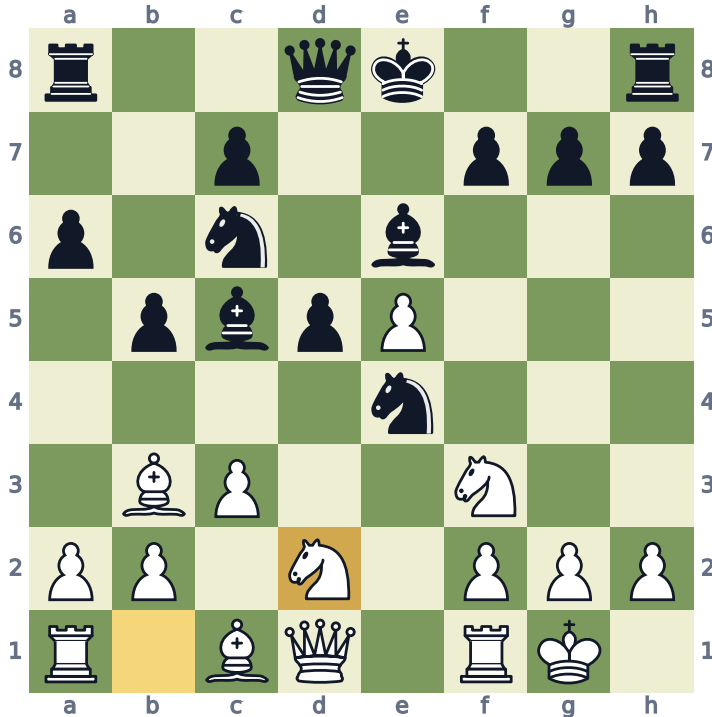
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



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Black defends d5 dynamically, castles, and uses piece activity to prevent White from collecting central pawns.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

WHITE'S PLAN

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FAILURE MODE

Black defending the pawn passively or White taking before completing the tactical sequence.

DECISION TEST

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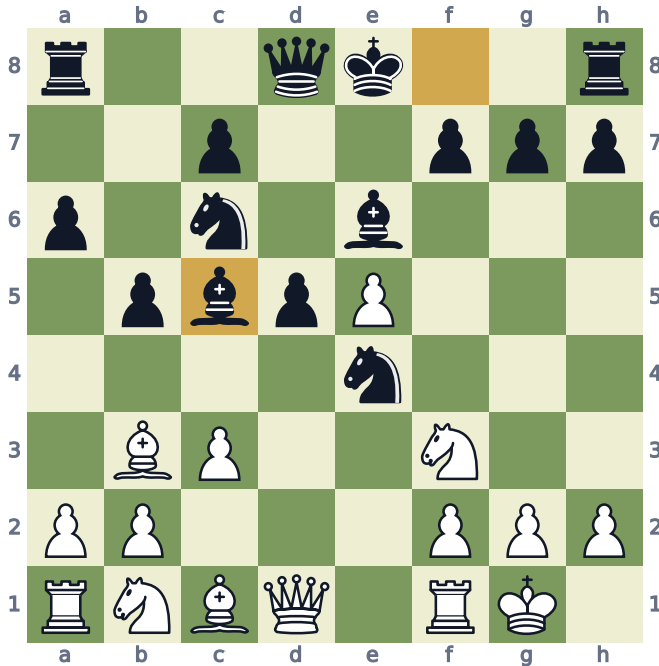
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6 9. c3 Bc5 10. Nbd2



- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d5: Black challenges the center or offers dynamic activity, depending on the system.
- dxe5: White releases tension by capturing on e5; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Be6: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- c3: White supports d4 and reserves c2 as a retreat square for the Spanish bishop.
- Bc5: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White does not chase the knight blindly; c3 and Nbd2 add pressure to the central base and improve development.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which defender of d5 is pinned, overloaded, or vulnerable to exchange? White's resource is: White attacks d5 and e4 while keeping tactical pressure on f7 and the pinned c6 knight. The line fails as a template when: Black defending the pawn passively or White taking before completing the tactical sequence.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

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1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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ANSWER KEY

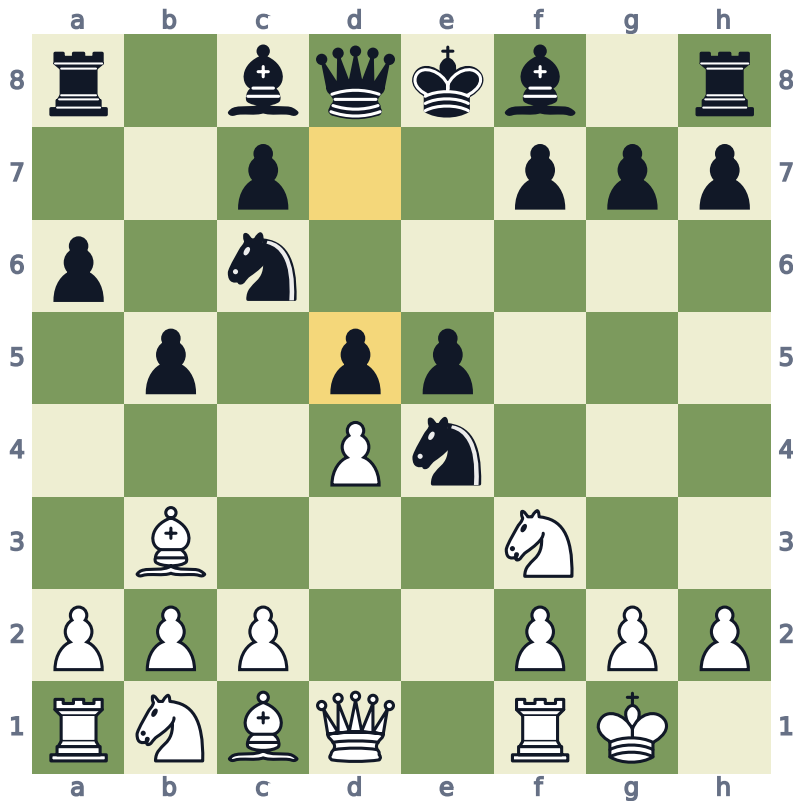
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6 9. c3 Bc5

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Piece activity as compensation



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black's center may later dissolve, so development and piece activity must create threats while it exists.

DECISION RULE

Does the proposed exchange preserve Black's activity or leave only structural targets?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Castle, centralize rooks, and use bishops on active diagonals before accepting simplification.

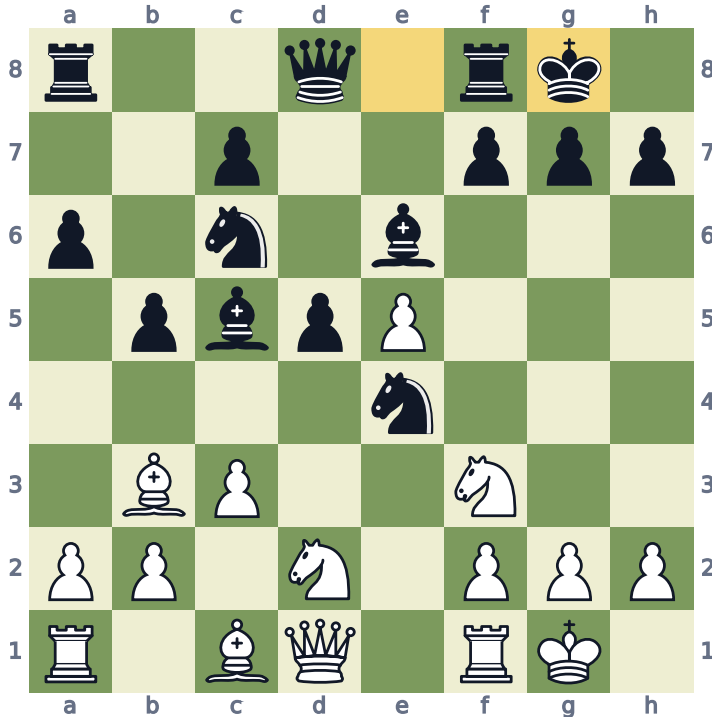
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White seeks exchanges that leave Black with weak central pawns and no initiative.

MEMORY RULE | Dynamic compensation expires; convert it into development, tactics, or a sound structure.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black's center may later dissolve, so development and piece activity must create threats while it exists.

BLACK'S PLAN

Castle, centralize rooks, and use bishops on active diagonals before accepting simplification.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White seeks exchanges that leave Black with weak central pawns and no initiative.

FAILURE MODE

Trading active pieces because it simplifies calculation while the center becomes weak.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does the proposed exchange preserve Black's activity or leave only structural targets? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

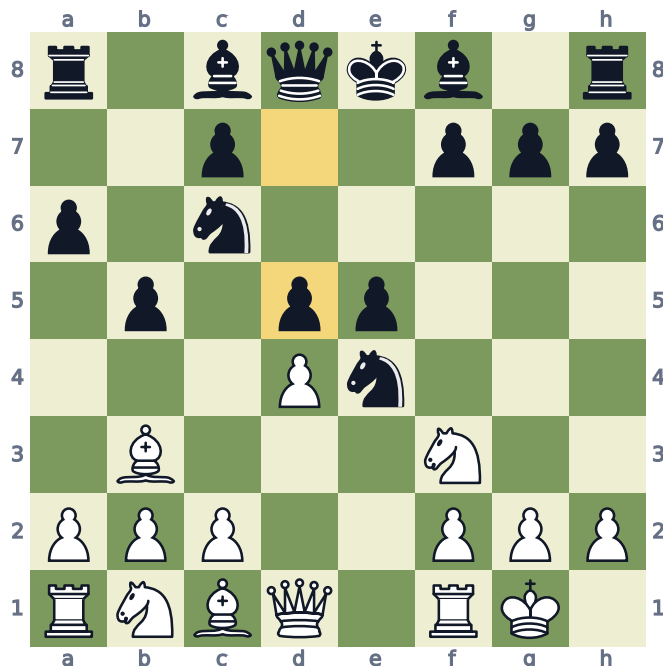
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6 9. c3 Bc5 10. Nbd2 O-O



- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Nxe4: Black releases tension by capturing on e4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
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WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

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WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does the proposed exchange preserve Black's activity or leave only structural targets? White's resource is: White seeks exchanges that leave Black with weak central pawns and no initiative. The line fails as a template when: Trading active pieces because it simplifies calculation while the center becomes weak.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

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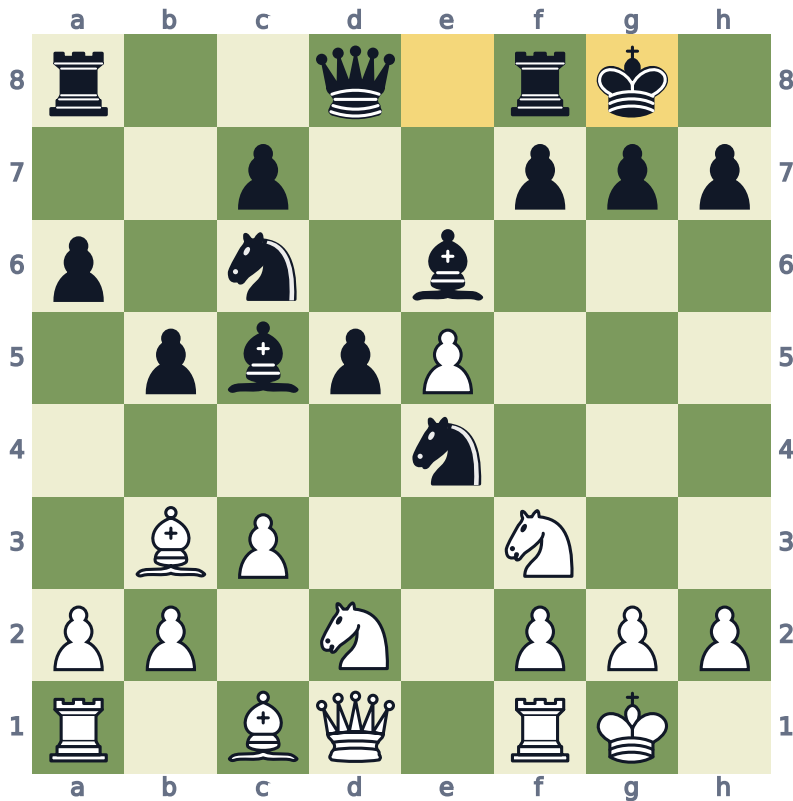
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Piece activity as compensation



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SIDE TO MOVE

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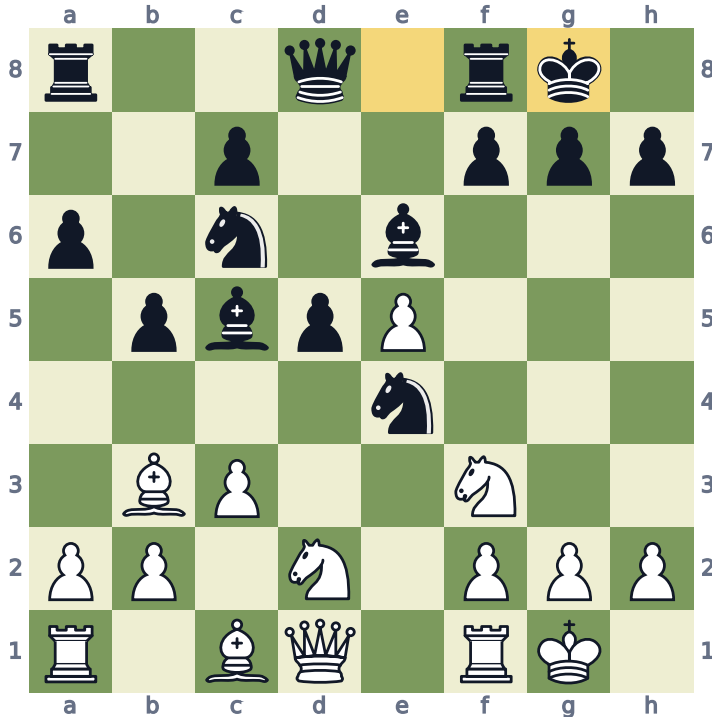
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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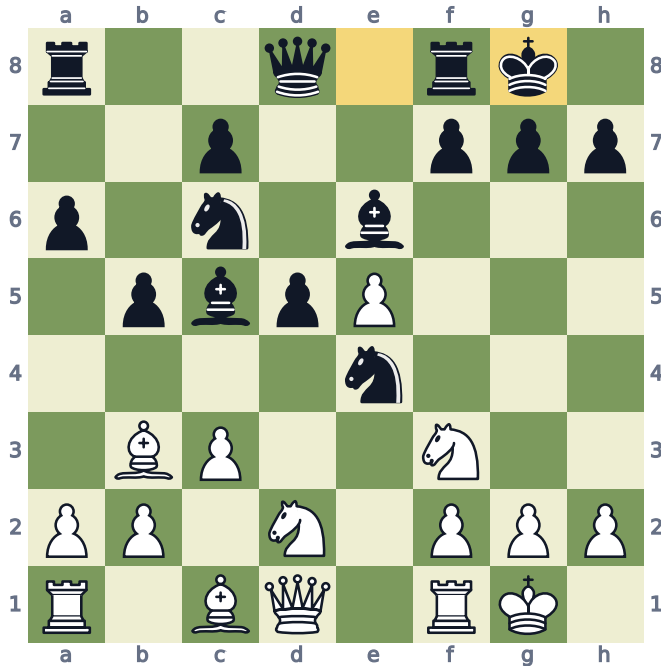
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- Bc5: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black's center may later dissolve, so development and piece activity must create threats while it exists.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does the proposed exchange preserve Black's activity or leave only structural targets? White's resource is: White seeks exchanges that leave Black with weak central pawns and no initiative. The line fails as a template when: Trading active pieces because it simplifies calculation while the center becomes weak.

STORE THIS | Dynamic compensation expires; convert it into development, tactics, or a sound structure.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Black's center may later dissolve, so development and piece activity must create threats while it exists. 2. Castle, centralize rooks, and use bishops on active diagonals before accepting simplification. 3. White seeks exchanges that leave Black with weak central pawns and no initiative. 4. Does the proposed exchange preserve Black's activity or leave only structural targets? 5. Trading active pieces because it simplifies calculation while the center becomes weak.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 20 plies from memory, then replay: 8. dxe5 Be6 9. c3 Bc5 10. Nbd2 O-O

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 055 Decode: Why 5...Nxe4 works

Prompt: After White's next forcing move, where can the e4 knight go and which pawn holds the center together?

Recall: The Open Spanish pawn capture is sound because the center arrives behind it.

LESSON 056 Play: Why 5...Nxe4 works

Prompt: After White's next forcing move, where can the e4 knight go and which pawn holds the center together?

Recall: The Open Spanish pawn capture is sound because the center arrives behind it.

LESSON 057 Decode: White attacks the d5 base

Prompt: Which defender of d5 is pinned, overloaded, or vulnerable to exchange?

Recall: Attack the base of an active center; its advanced piece often depends on it.

LESSON 058 Play: White attacks the d5 base

Prompt: Which defender of d5 is pinned, overloaded, or vulnerable to exchange?

Recall: Attack the base of an active center; its advanced piece often depends on it.

LESSON 059 Decode: Piece activity as compensation

Prompt: Does the proposed exchange preserve Black's activity or leave only structural targets?

Recall: Dynamic compensation expires; convert it into development, tactics, or a sound structure.

LESSON 060 Play: Piece activity as compensation

Prompt: Does the proposed exchange preserve Black's activity or leave only structural targets?

Recall: Dynamic compensation expires; convert it into development, tactics, or a sound structure.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's plan, one candidate for the side to move, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Why 5...Nxe4 works

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6

Decision: After White's next forcing move, where can the e4 knight go and which pawn holds the center together?

Memory: The Open Spanish pawn capture is sound because the center arrives behind it.

CARD 2

White attacks the d5 base

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6 9. c3 Bc5 10. Nbd2

Decision: Which defender of d5 is pinned, overloaded, or vulnerable to exchange?

Memory: Attack the base of an active center; its advanced piece often depends on it.

CARD 3

Piece activity as compensation

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Nxe4 6. d4 b5 7. Bb3 d5 8. dxe5 Be6 9. c3 Bc5 10. Nbd2 O-O

Decision: Does the proposed exchange preserve Black's activity or leave only structural targets?

Memory: Dynamic compensation expires; convert it into development, tactics, or a sound structure.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
055 Decode: Why 5...Nxe4 works	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
056 Play: Why 5...Nxe4 works	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
057 Decode: White attacks the d5 base	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
058 Play: White attacks the d5 base	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
059 Decode: Piece activity as compensation	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
060 Play: Piece activity as compensation	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name both sides' strongest plans, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.